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1929, Jail Readings

According to Simona Sawhney, '[t]he revolutionaries have often been judged as romantic, immature, or misguided' but that does less than full justice to how Bhagat Singh himself ultimately justified his actions. There is a moment when he 'outgrew romance'[1] because, as he explains in relation to the mass arrests after the Kakori incident in 1925, 'Till that time I was only a romantic revolutionary, just a follower of our leaders. Then came the time to shoulder the whole responsibility.'[2] But the way Bhagat Singh did this was through 'study'. As he explains, 'Enthusiastic comrades – nay, leader – began to jeer at us. For some time I was afraid that some day I also might not be convinced of the utility of our programme. That was the turning point in my revolutionary career: "Study" was the cry that reverberated in the corridors of my mind.' This is what brought about the ultimate transformation in his life. Hence, 'Study to enable yourself to face the arguments advanced by [the] opposition' but also 'study to arm yourself with arguments in favour of your cult (*sic*). I began to study'.[3] So complete was his transformation that Ajoy Ghosh attests to how when he first met Bhagat Singh in 1923 aged sixteen, having been introduced to him by B.K. Dutt in Cawnpore, what he saw was a 'tall and thin rather shabbily dressed, very quiet' young man who seemed nothing more than 'a typical village lad lacking smartness and self confidence', such that 'I did not think very highly of him and told Dutt so when he was alone'. And yet, five years later 'one day in 1928, I was surprised when a young man walked into my room and greeted me . . . but it was not the Bhagat Singh that I had met . . . before'. For this twenty-one-year old was 'tall and magnificently proportioned, with a keen, intelligent face and gleaming eyes' and 'he